multifaceted prism as well as contemporary reference points through which the world is perceived by the Chinese. Even to this day, much of Chinese discourse is conducted through historical analogies, some of which are explicit and well known, while some are artfully coded, the language lending itself easily to innuendo and ambiguity. India offers a stark contrast in that it has very sparse written records of its history and it is extremely difficult to work out the chronology of events before the medieval period. The major points of reference are the epics – the Ramayana and the Mahabharata – and several compilations in regional languages, which may reflect some remembered events in the distant past but are mostly legend.

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In the book *What China and India Once Were* ,[4] edited by Sheldon Pollock and Benjamin Elman, both well-known scholars of Indian and East Asian history and culture, some other differences between the two cultures have been highlighted. In China, poetry can be understood and appreciated only in the context of time and place. In India, epic poetry is marked by a certain timelessness and preoccupation with eternal verities. The historical context is unimportant. Painting in China, the book points out, was the domain of the scholar-artist. In India, it remained until recently an artisanal pursuit, with the painter rarely known or commended. China had its version of the ideal and versatile intellectual, accomplished in poetry, music, calligraphy and painting. India had its poets, litterateurs and musicians, but rarely figures accomplished in multiple domains. In China it was not unusual to have a painting by a famous artist include a verse from a well-known poet written in the hand of an accomplished calligrapher. The painting may carry the seal of the painter, but then also those of its successive owners. It is not unusual to find a number of such seals on Chinese paintings exhibited in different museums of the world.

While serving as a diplomat in Beijing I had organized an exhibition of paintings by a Chinese artist whose forte was painting cats in different moods and in different settings. He had set up a table with inks and brushes for a live demonstration of his art and had invited several other Chinese